



Impact rescue: Sarfaraz Khan became Chennai Super Kings' emergency lever, twice arriving as an Impact Player inside the PowerPlay after early wickets exposed the top order. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Impact Player largely because the squad offered few alternatives, with Ajinkya Rahane the captain, Angkrish Raghuvanshi keeping wickets, Anukul Roy and Cameron Green as all-rounders, and the rest of the side's best fielders.

There are very few examples of teams maintaining a fixed Impact Player exchange. Sunrisers Hyderabad settled into a rhythm of swapping Travis Head and Sakib Hussain in the second half of the season, while Gujarat Titans generally alternated between Prasidh Krishna and either Rahul Tewatia or Shahrukh Khan. Far more common was a setup where only one side of the substitution remained fixed.

All in the plan

Some players effectively became designated Impact Players for specific situations. Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, for instance, was often substituted into matches while Rajasthan Royals was chasing to keep him fresh for batting, but was substituted out only once when the side batted first. Similarly, Punjab Kings regularly substituted Yuzvendra Chahal out while chasing, but never once brought him in when batting first. Instead, it kept him in the playing XI named at the toss and substituted another player in.

This likely preserves the flexibility to deviate from the standard one-batter, one-bowler template by using an extra batter as the Impact Player when a team's top-order collapses while batting first. No side embraced this strategy more aggressively than Chennai Super Kings, which twice brought in Sarfaraz Khan inside the PowerPlay when it had lost early wickets.

Making the case for flexibility

CSK is also one of the few franchises that employed a more flexible method, often swapping between bringing in an extra seamer or an extra spinner depending on conditions.

The franchise's approach exploited an interesting fact about the Impact Player rule that has generally been underexplored: that the player brought in as an Impact Player allows a team to improve its chances of victory by reacting to the game state.

A parallel can be drawn in football, where substitutions are made with knowledge of the state of the match and tailored to exploit opportunities or address weaknesses.

The Impact Player is theoretically similar. While the XI is selected with imperfect information, the substitution can be made with nearly 20 overs' worth of evidence at hand.

There were signs of teams beginning to exploit this towards the